

LEVEL 1 . ASHWORTH PARTNERS

Inside the day at Ashworth Partners.

Operational EA . Monday morning . 60-minute assessment

Scenarios rotate. The day described here is illustrative. The version a candidate actually sits may not be the one shown.

Ashworth Partners is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 1. This briefing describes the day a candidate is dropped into, the principals they support, and what the assessment is actually testing. The exact tasks, traps and answer keys stay confidential, which is what makes the score mean something. Everything below is the marketable surface.

THE MORNING

Monday, 09:35. The kettle has just clicked off. The inbox has been filling since eight. You are sitting at the executive assistant desk at Ashworth Partners, a London management consulting firm of around a hundred and fifty people, built twelve years ago by Sarah Chen and David Ashworth, and the day is about to start asking questions of you.

THE PRINCIPALS

Sarah is the Managing Partner. David is the Operations Director. You support both of them. They built this firm together. They run it together. On most days they have the same idea about how it should be run, and on the days when they don't, you are usually the first person to find out. Sarah is strategic, composed, client-facing. She communicates sparingly and dislikes being interrupted with small decisions. David is hands-on, decisive, and likes to approve things before they happen. Their messages have different rhythms. So does their tolerance for ambiguity.

THE WEEK

Today is the first proper Monday of an unusually full week. Two large client deliverables land on Thursday. David has a board prep tomorrow afternoon. There is a networking event tomorrow evening. Half the team is at an offsite in Birmingham, which means the office is quieter than usual but the administrative cushion is thinner. Sarah is travelling to a client site and will be on calls until midday, reachable by email but not by phone. David is in back-to-back internal meetings, his door closed, his phone on for urgent matters.

LEVEL 1 . CONTINUED**WHAT SITS IN THE INBOX**

Twelve messages have landed since you logged off last night. None of them is dramatic on its own. Several are quietly load-bearing. A supplier confirmation that buries a real catering deadline four paragraphs in. A request from Sarah for a discreet slot with David, with no topic on the invite. A diary change from David that, taken at face value, will land on top of one of Sarah's recurring blocks. Reception escalating something the junior receptionist isn't sure whether to act on. A meeting invite that looks routine and is not.

WHAT THE DAY ASKS OF YOU

The operational core of the EA role. Not heroics. The quiet, accurate, on-time handling of competing demands when the principal isn't standing over you. Holding two equal-standing partners' instructions without exposing either. Making the small decisions yourself so the principal doesn't have to. Knowing which item you cannot leave to lunchtime, and which one you can. Drafting in Sarah's voice when she isn't there to dictate.

THE CANDIDATE

One to three years into the profession, past the first six months of learning a principal's rhythm, with the basics already in muscle memory. Reports primarily to Sarah with a working dotted line to David. Not yet making commercial proxy-judgement calls. Not yet managing other EAs. Operational, tactical, close to the desk.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

Whether the candidate can do the operational core of the EA role under real time pressure, with real competing demands, and without the principal needing to stand over them. The four pillars apply at L1 with the weighting tilted to operational altitude. Prioritisation 40%. Communication 30%. Acuity 20%. Execution 10%.

Prioritisation dominates because the operational EA's daily reality is a constant stream of small decisions about what to do first.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Twelve to fourteen pages, scored against a published rubric, reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours of submission. It tells the employer, based on what the candidate actually did rather than what they said about their work, whether the candidate is an L1 fit and where the strengths and the gaps sit.

Reference-ready extracts on request.

LEVEL 1 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Ashworth scenario is set inside a consulting firm. The altitude, the four-pillar weighting and the rubric do not change with sector. What changes is the day's stakeholder set and the texture of the inbox. Here is how Level 1 reads in three of the contexts buyers ask us about most.

L1 IN A TECH SCALE-UP

Picture a Series B founder-CEO who came up technical, alongside a COO brought in to professionalise operations. The EA holds both diaries, runs investor meeting logistics, manages the founder's calendar of one-to-ones, and quietly translates between the technical rhythm of the founder and the operating rhythm of the COO. The day-shape changes. More Slack, fewer printed papers, more travel. The core test is identical: can the EA hold two equal-altitude principals without losing the thread on either.

L1 IN A LAW OR ACCOUNTANCY PARTNERSHIP

Picture a senior partner inside a mid-sized professional services firm. The candidate supports a partner who is both a fee-earner and a manager. The diary blocks include billable client time, internal partner meetings, and a long-running matter that sits underneath everything. The texture is more formal than Ashworth, the discretion bar higher, the cadence set by the firm's billing cycle. The L1 muscle of triage, draft, sequence, and hold the line is what is being tested. The answer key shifts only in surface form.

L1 IN A CREATIVE OR MEDIA AGENCY

Picture a senior creative director with a fluid set of clients, deliverables that cluster around a pitch, and a working pattern that doesn't sit neatly inside a 9-to-5. The EA is the protector of the creative day, the buffer between the principal and the production team, the one who keeps the diary from collapsing during pitch week. The pace is faster than Ashworth, the formality lower, the politics different. The four pillars and the L1 weighting are the same. The candidate either has the operational discipline or doesn't, and the report tells you which.

COMMISSION THE ASSESSMENT

EA Hire L1 is £495 +VAT per candidate. Briefing form returns the same working day. First report in 48 hours. Commission at thecorestandard.co.uk/ea-hire.